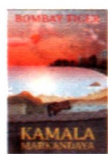


HER LAST HURRAH

Markandaya's posthumously published novel follows an ambitious industrialist through a dramatic plot



BOMBAY TIGER
by KAMALA MARKANDAYA
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■ By Gillian Wright

India's national animal is the royal Bengal tiger. Perhaps in recognition of this fact, the predatory central figure of Kamala Markandaya's novel chooses to change his name from Gokhle to Ganguli. Markandaya endows him with the kind of presence that compels a crocodile to make way for him when they meet on a track in his native village. She also gives him a competitor, the caste-conscious Narahari Rao, and they both set out for Bombay to make it big in finance. The difference is that between a tiger and a jungle cat—one aims at much more substantial prey.

At school, Ganguli's history teacher had summed up the British Raj in the phrase "their greed, our stupidity". Reversing this, Ganguli makes his own motto, "my greed, their stupidity", and through audacious moves in the construction business, he comes to a grandiose scheme for which he needs weighty foreign investment. If Dhirubhai Ambani had imagined every Indian woman wrapped in a Vimal sari, the fictional Ganguli's aim is to invent the people's fridge.

The vast riches of today's captains of Indian industry make even Ganguli at the height of his success seem comparatively small beer. Markandaya does not make him go out, for example, and buy Whirlpool or Samsung. But that is because the businessman is constrained by the period in which the novel is set, the 1980s, before liberalisation. However, many of the issues Markandaya

addresses are still important in today's India.

Ganguli represents capitalism at its most amoral and irresponsible. But he could not have gripped the attention that he does if there was not more to him than that. He is a man free of all pretensions, regarding equally people of all classes and castes. He enjoys life, is indulgent to his beautiful but rather simple-minded daughter and is not hypocritical when it comes to sex. A doctor, the son of his schoolteacher, provides a foil for him, raising issues of workers' rights and the urban poor. Even Ganguli's lawyer-friend has a convincing set of scruples, including an abhorrence of the death penalty. In short, Markandaya creates a cast of characters with sufficient depth and complexity to complement Ganguli's personality. These even include a budding woman astronaut.

Much of the plot is narrated by the characters themselves, looking back at the past. They drop tantalising hints of

FICTION FINESSE: This is Markandaya's eleventh novel

the dramatic turns the plot takes. One of these—the arrival of a Hollywood film crew—allows the author plenty of scope for humorous potshots at clichéd views of India.

Sadly, Markandaya did not live to see this novel published. It is her eleventh. Her first, *Nectar in a Sieve*, about an educated but poor village woman, was published in 1954 to much acclaim in the United States, although it did not do so well in Britain. Her last novel before this, *Shalimar*, was published in 1982. She then spent years working on *Bombay Tiger*, but could not find a publisher either in Britain, where she lived, or in the US. Editors found the book too long, and the present version was discovered by her daughter among her papers after her death.

In her lifetime, Markandaya had trouble not only with editors and publishers but greedy agents and destructive critics whom she called "those louts who enjoy destroying a writer's ego". However, Charles R. Larson, professor of literature at the American University, Washington, in his introduction to *Bombay Tiger*, considers her one of the four major novelists from India writing in English during the mid-point of the 20th century, the other three he names being Mulk Raj Anand, R.K. Narayan and Raja Rao. He believes that these four writers reshaped the concept of 'world literature' in the West and that Markandaya was the only one of them to have had a feminist perspective.

In the 20 years since Markandaya began writing *Bombay Tiger*, the world of Indian fiction in English has expanded exponentially. Many of today's authors acknowledge their debt to her. The long-overdue publication reminds us all of her talent and the rightful place she enjoys in Indian fiction. ■

